Acknowledgements

This book and much of our intellectual journey would not have been possible without the intellectual munificence of Shruti Kapila and the late C.A. Bayly. They first put us on track to examining the complex soil of Indian politics at the University of Cambridge and nurtured our burgeoning interest in its conceptual foundations – an interest that has since blossomed through many rewarding conversations with James Manor, Faisal Devji, Javed Majeed, Tahir Kamran, Sujit Sivasundaram, Meghnad Desai and Philip Murphy. We have further greatly benefited from our respective academic homes and would like to express our gratitude to the School of Advanced Study, University of London and Leiden University for their support, as well as the British Academy for generous funding of Tripurdaman's research. Tripurdaman Singh would also like to thank Mushtaq Qureshi for having been a great source of encouragement and guidance.

We have been very fortunate in having had the excellent companionship of friends and colleagues who have been our intellectual interlocutors and helped us think through the themes and arguments of this book: Anshul Avijit, Ali Khan Mahmudabad, Amir Khan, Mariam Chauhan, Adam Lebovitz, Parul Bhandari, Alastair McClure, Saumya Saxena, Siraj Khan, Jonah Schulhofer-Wohl, Nicolas Blarel, Francesco Ragazzi, Zareer Masani, Narayani Basu and Harshan Kumarasingham.

Thanks are also due to Swati Chopra and Antony Thomas at HarperCollins India, who have been instrumental in putting this book together, and Arabella Pike at William Collins, our publisher in the UK. As ever, our agent Kanishka Gupta has been very diligent and made the whole process as smooth as possible. We would also like to thank the Navajivan Trust for allowing us to reprint the relevant extracts from Sardar Patel's correspondence.